SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Monitoring, Evaluation and Outcomes - Solved Practice Workbook

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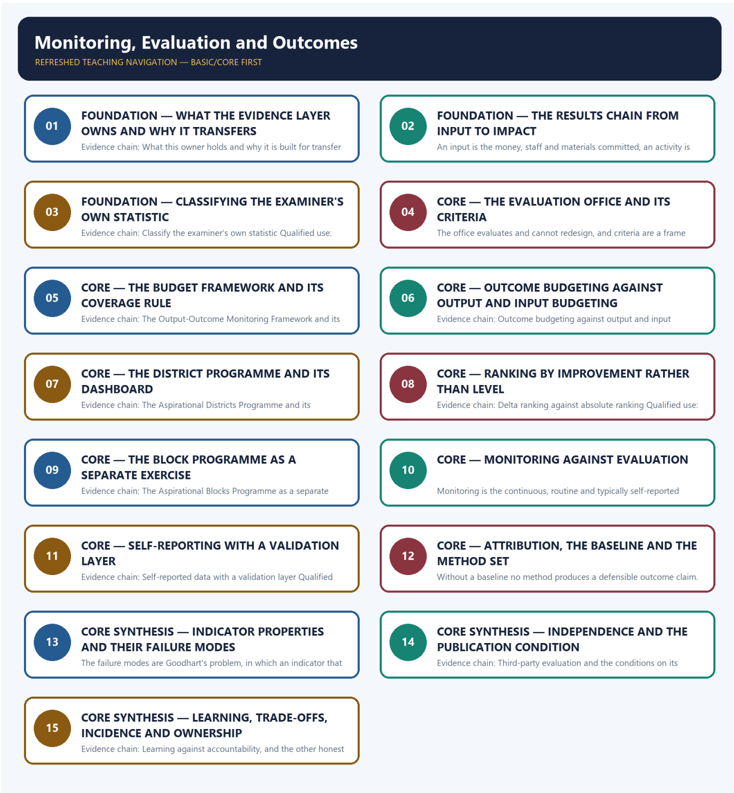

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Monitoring, Evaluation and Outcomes - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies What this owner holds and why it is built for transfer?

A. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. B. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. C. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. D. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung.

Answer: A. Explanation: This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q2. Which chronology card should be filed under What this owner holds and why it is built for transfer?

A. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. B. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. C. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. D. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one.

Answer: B. Explanation: This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What this owner holds and why it is built for transfer?

A. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. B. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. C. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. D. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves.

Answer: C. Explanation: This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What this owner holds and why it is built for transfer?

A. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. B. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. C. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation

Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. D. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner.

Answer: D. Explanation: This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies Input, activity, output, outcome and impact?

A. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. B. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. C. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. D. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect.

Answer: A. Explanation: An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q6. Which chronology card should be filed under Input, activity, output, outcome and impact?

A. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. B. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. C. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. D. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect.

Answer: B. Explanation: An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Input, activity, output, outcome and impact?

A. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. B. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. C. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. D. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.

Answer: C. Explanation: An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Input, activity, output, outcome and impact?

A. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. B. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. C. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. D. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung.

Answer: D. Explanation: An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies The results chain as the spine of every evaluative answer?

A. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. B. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. C. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. D. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect.

Answer: A. Explanation: The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q10. Which chronology card should be filed under The results chain as the spine of every evaluative answer?

A. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. B. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. C. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. D. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.

Answer: B. Explanation: The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The results chain as the spine of every evaluative answer?

A. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. B. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. C. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. D. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.

Answer: C. Explanation: The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The results chain as the spine of every evaluative answer?

A. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. B. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. C. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. D. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one.

Answer: D. Explanation: The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies Classify the examiner's own statistic?

A. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. B. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. C. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. D. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.

Answer: A. Explanation: The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q14. Which chronology card should be filed under Classify the examiner's own statistic?

A. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. B. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. C. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. D. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves.

Answer: B. Explanation: The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Classify the examiner's own statistic?

A. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. B. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. C. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. D. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district.

Answer: C. Explanation: The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Classify the examiner's own statistic?

A. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. B. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. C. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. D. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect.

Answer: D. Explanation: The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office and its mandate?

A. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. B. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. C. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. D. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q18. Which chronology card should be filed under The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office and its mandate?

A. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. B. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. C. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. D. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office and its mandate?

A. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. B. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. C. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. D. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office and its mandate?

A. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. B. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. C. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. D. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies The REESI plus coherence and equity criteria?

A. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. B. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. C. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. D. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district.

Answer: A. Explanation: The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q22. Which chronology card should be filed under The REESI plus coherence and equity criteria?

A. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. B. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. C. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. D. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests.

Answer: B. Explanation: The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The REESI plus coherence and equity criteria?

A. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. B. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. C. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. D. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district.

Answer: C. Explanation: The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The REESI plus coherence and equity criteria?

A. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. B. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. C. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. D. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves.

Answer: D. Explanation: The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework and its coverage rule?

A. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. B. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. C. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. D. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q26. Which chronology card should be filed under The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework and its coverage rule?

A. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. B. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. C. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. D. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework and its coverage rule?

A. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. B. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. C. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. D. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework and its coverage rule?

A. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. B. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. C. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. D. The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies Outcome budgeting against output and input budgeting?

A. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. B. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. C. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. D. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district.

Answer: A. Explanation: Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q30. Which chronology card should be filed under Outcome budgeting against output and input budgeting?

A. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. B. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. C. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. D. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests.

Answer: B. Explanation: Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Outcome budgeting against output and input budgeting?

A. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. B. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. C. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. D. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers.

Answer: C. Explanation: Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Outcome budgeting against output and input budgeting?

A. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. B. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. C. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. D. Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice.

Answer: D. Explanation: Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies The Aspirational Districts Programme and its dashboard architecture?

A. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. B. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. C. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. D. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q34. Which chronology card should be filed under The Aspirational Districts Programme and its dashboard architecture?

A. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. B. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. C. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. D. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Aspirational Districts Programme and its dashboard architecture?

A. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. B. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. C. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. D. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Aspirational Districts Programme and its dashboard architecture?

A. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. B. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. C. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. D. The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies Delta ranking against absolute ranking?

A. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. B. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. C. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. D. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers.

Answer: A. Explanation: Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q38. Which chronology card should be filed under Delta ranking against absolute ranking?

A. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. B. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. C. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. D. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch.

Answer: B. Explanation: Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Delta ranking against absolute ranking?

A. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. B. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. C. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. D. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch.

Answer: C. Explanation: Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Delta ranking against absolute ranking?

A. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. B. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. C. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. D. Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests.

Answer: D. Explanation: Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies The Aspirational Blocks Programme as a separate exercise?

A. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. B. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. C. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. D. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs.

Answer: A. Explanation: A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q42. Which chronology card should be filed under The Aspirational Blocks Programme as a separate exercise?

A. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. B. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. C. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. D. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data.

Answer: B. Explanation: A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Aspirational Blocks Programme as a separate exercise?

A. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. B. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. C. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. D. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data.

Answer: C. Explanation: A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Aspirational Blocks Programme as a separate exercise?

A. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. B. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. C. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. D. A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block.

Answer: D. Explanation: A related Aspirational Blocks Programme extends a similar logic to the sub-district level and is recorded in current NITI Aayog material as covering five hundred and thirteen blocks, and the analytical requirement is to keep the two programmes separate, because merging district and block unit counts or their indicator sets is the standard factual error in this area; the finer unit exists precisely because a district average can conceal a failing block. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies Monitoring and evaluation are complementary and distinct?

A. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. B. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. C. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. D. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data.

Answer: A. Explanation: Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. The

remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q46. Which chronology card should be filed under Monitoring and evaluation are complementary and distinct?

A. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. B. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. C. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. D. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data.

Answer: B. Explanation: Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Monitoring and evaluation are complementary and distinct?

A. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. B. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. C. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. D. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks.

Answer: C. Explanation: Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Monitoring and evaluation are complementary and distinct?

A. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. B. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. C. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. D. Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers.

Answer: D. Explanation: Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies Self-reported data with a validation layer?

A. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. B. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. C. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. D. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data.

Answer: A. Explanation: The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q50. Which chronology card should be filed under Self-reported data with a validation layer?

A. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. B. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. C. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. D. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks.

Answer: B. Explanation: The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Self-reported data with a validation layer?

A. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. B. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. C. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. D. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism.

Answer: C. Explanation: The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Self-reported data with a validation layer?

A. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. B. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. C. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. D. The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch.

Answer: D. Explanation: The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies Attribution is the hard problem and the baseline is the precondition?

A. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. B. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. C. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. D. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data.

Answer: A. Explanation: The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q54. Which chronology card should be filed under Attribution is the hard problem and the baseline is the precondition?

A. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. B. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. C. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. D. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism.

Answer: B. Explanation: The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Attribution is the hard problem and the baseline is the precondition?

A. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. B. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. C. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. D. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism.

Answer: C. Explanation: The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Attribution is the hard problem and the baseline is the precondition?

A. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. B. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. C. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. D. The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs.

Answer: D. Explanation: The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies What each evaluation method can and cannot establish?

A. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. B. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. C. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. D. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks.

Answer: A. Explanation: A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q58. Which chronology card should be filed under What each evaluation method can and cannot establish?

A. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. B. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. C. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. D. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism.

Answer: B. Explanation: A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally

implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What each evaluation method can and cannot establish?

A. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. B. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. C. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. D. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package.

Answer: C. Explanation: A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the

effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What each evaluation method can and cannot establish?

A. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. B. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. C. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. D. A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data.

Answer: D. Explanation: A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. The remaining options belong to

different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies What makes an indicator usable?

A. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. B. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. C. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. D. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism.

Answer: A. Explanation: A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q62. Which chronology card should be filed under What makes an indicator usable?

A. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. B. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. C. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. D. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism.

Answer: B. Explanation: A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What makes an indicator usable?

A. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. B. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. C. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. D. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package.

Answer: C. Explanation: A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What makes an indicator usable?

A. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. B. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. C. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. D. A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose.

Answer: D. Explanation: A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies The six indicator failure modes and their corrections?

A. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. B. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. C. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. D. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package.

Answer: A. Explanation: The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q66. Which chronology card should be filed under The six indicator failure modes and their corrections?

A. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. B. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. C. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. D. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner.

Answer: B. Explanation: The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The six indicator failure modes and their corrections?

A. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. B. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. C. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. D. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung.

Answer: C. Explanation: The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The six indicator failure modes and their corrections?

A. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. B. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. C. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. D. The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks.

Answer: D. Explanation: The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies Third-party evaluation and the conditions on its independence?

A. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. B. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. C. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. D. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism.

Answer: A. Explanation: Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q70. Which chronology card should be filed under Third-party evaluation and the conditions on its independence?

A. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. B. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. C. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. D. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package.

Answer: B. Explanation: Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Third-party evaluation and the conditions on its independence?

A. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. B. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. C. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. D. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one.

Answer: C. Explanation: Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Third-party evaluation and the conditions on its independence?

A. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. B. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. C. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. D. Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism.

Answer: D. Explanation: Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency

assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies Learning against accountability, and the other honest trade-offs?

A. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. B. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. C. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. D. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung.

Answer: A. Explanation: Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q74. Which chronology card should be filed under Learning against accountability, and the other honest trade-offs?

A. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. B. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. C. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. D. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner.

Answer: B. Explanation: Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Learning against accountability, and the other honest trade-offs?

A. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. B. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. C. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. D. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one.

Answer: C. Explanation: Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Learning against accountability, and the other honest trade-offs?

A. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. B. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. C. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. D. Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism.

Answer: D. Explanation: Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Incidence, the learning loop and honest question ownership?

A. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. B. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. C. This topic owns the evidence layer of governance, namely how a claim that a scheme worked is established or refuted, and its distinctive feature is that no direct General Studies Mains demand in the audited 2018 to 2025 ledgers is routed to it, so it appears as the evaluative half of demands about schemes, governance quality and expenditure; the architecture is therefore built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and the measurement of governance quality by composite indices belongs to the good-governance owner while the policy cycle belongs to the policy-design owner. D. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung.

Answer: A. Explanation: The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q78. Which chronology card should be filed under Incidence, the learning loop and honest question ownership?

A. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. B. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. C. An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. D. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect.

Answer: B. Explanation: The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Incidence, the learning loop and honest question ownership?

A. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. B. The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. C. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. D. The

Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect.

Answer: C. Explanation: The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Incidence, the learning loop and honest question ownership?

A. The office's evaluation criteria are relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability and impact together with coherence and equity, and they supply a ready frame for any demand that uses the word evaluate, because they prevent impact from being reduced to output completion and force distributional effects to be stated explicitly; the criteria are a frame rather than evidence, so they organise an answer and never substitute for the findings themselves. B. The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. C. The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. D. The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package.

Answer: D. Explanation: The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time,

the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. The remaining options belong to different chronology, actor or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

TRANSPARENT ZERO-DIRECT-PYQ AUDIT

No direct General Studies Mains demand and no applied objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 routing ledgers is routed to this topic, and the Basic owner records the same position expressly, so this package carries a transparent zero-direct-question audit rather than a manufactured demand card. No question has been invented from the locally held OCR-searchable official papers, no stem has been paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no official answer key or marking scheme has been consulted for this topic because none is applicable. The examinable consequence is stated openly instead: this topic appears in the examination as the evaluative half of demands owned elsewhere, such as assessing a scheme's effectiveness, judging governance quality or scrutinising expenditure, so the six original solved Mains answers below are built for transfer to an unfamiliar programme rather than for a remembered question, and every figure used is carried with its owner-verified status date and its year. No district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is recorded or inferred anywhere in this package.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

9. PYQ application

- ANALYSIS: No GS-II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers names DMEO/OOMF/Aspirational

Districts directly, but this file's output-outcome distinction is directly useful background for any question evaluating scheme effectiveness, governance performance measurement (see `01`'s GGI discussion), or implementation quality (see `02`).

- ANALYSIS: Use the output-outcome distinction as the standard analytical opening whenever a

question asks you to "evaluate" or "assess the impact" of any government scheme or programme.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- ANALYSIS: Where a question asks to "evaluate" or "assess the impact" of any scheme or reform

across the Governance syllabus (e.g., e-governance in `05`, DBT in `13`, or local governance in `12`), apply this file's monitoring-versus-evaluation and output-versus- outcome distinctions explicitly to strengthen the analytical rigor of the answer, rather than citing only output-level statistics.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Distinguish output indicators from outcome indicators in the evaluation of a government scheme, with an Indian example. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The distinction is the difference between what was produced and what changed, so the answer must build the results chain, classify a concrete indicator on it and name one limitation of the evidence rather than listing institutions.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung.
- The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one.
- The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect.
- The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district.

Qualified conclusion: The distinction is the difference between what was produced and what changed, so the answer must build the results chain, classify a concrete indicator on it and name one limitation of the evidence rather than listing institutions.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Distinguish output indicators from outcome indicators in the evaluation of a government…”, every clause, exact authority and institutional boundary, an implementation chain, stakeholder/accountability map, Centre-state-local allocation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The distinction is the difference between what was produced and what changed, so the answer must build the results chain, classify a concrete indicator on it and name one limitation of the evidence rather than listing institutions.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** An input is the money, staff and materials committed, an activity is what was done, an output is what the activity directly produced such as kilometres of road or schools constructed, an outcome is the change in the target population's condition such as reduced travel time or improved learning, and an impact is the longer-term and wider change such as market access, income or mobility; outputs are necessary evidence and are never sufficient evidence that the intended change occurred, and most Indian scheme reporting stops at the output rung. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The move that earns marks is to name the rung on which a cited statistic sits, because a figure such as the share of households covered is an output while a figure such as water quality at the

point of use is an outcome, so performing that classification on the examiner's own number demonstrates both the criteria and the evidence discipline at once and prevents an answer from treating coverage as proof of effect. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

Counter-position / limit: A constitutional value, commission recommendation, scheme catalogue, budget allocation, portal, disposal count or ranking cannot alone establish lawful authority, inclusive implementation, substantive remedy or attributable outcome; test capacity, federal competence, distribution, privacy, audit, appeal and current operative status.

Qualified conclusion: The distinction is the difference between what was produced and what changed, so the answer must build the results chain, classify a concrete indicator on it and name one limitation of the evidence rather than listing institutions.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing authority -> institution -> delivery -> outcome -> remedy; define and state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for inclusion, privacy, federal, indicator, grievance and current-status limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains implementation rather than listing schemes, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves legal, federal, institutional, causal and outcome distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Distinguish output indicators from outcome indicators in the evaluation of a government…”, replace the weakest catalogue-style point with one named duty-holder, legal or executive basis, delivery bottleneck, process and outcome indicator, grievance route and evidence-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Examine the design choice of ranking districts by the pace of improvement rather than by absolute level. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: Delta ranking solves a real demotivation problem created by absolute ranking and introduces a real baseline-gaming problem in its place, so the examination must state the incentive logic and the validation condition on which its credibility depends.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests.
- The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district

unit necessarily masks divergence within a district.

- The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch.
- The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package.

Qualified conclusion: Delta ranking solves a real demotivation problem created by absolute ranking and introduces a real baseline-gaming problem in its place, so the examination must state the incentive logic and the validation condition on which its credibility depends.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Examine the design choice of ranking districts by the pace of improvement rather than by…”, every clause, exact authority and institutional boundary, an implementation chain, stakeholder/accountability map, Centre-state-local allocation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Delta ranking solves a real demotivation problem created by absolute ranking and introduces a real baseline-gaming problem in its place, so the examination must state the incentive logic and the validation condition on which its credibility depends.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Absolute ranking compares units on their present level and therefore favours already-advantaged units, while delta ranking compares the rate of improvement over a defined period and therefore rewards effort regardless of the starting position, which is a deliberate incentive-design choice that prevents a historically disadvantaged district from being permanently placed at the bottom; the corresponding risk is that any improvement-based metric can be gamed through baseline understatement, so careful baseline-setting and independent validation are the conditions on which its credibility rests. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The Aspirational Districts Programme of NITI Aayog covers one hundred and twelve districts and tracks forty-nine key performance indicators across five themes, namely health and nutrition, education, agriculture and water resources, financial inclusion and skill development, and basic infrastructure, through the Champions of Change dashboard with a delta-ranking system, and its distinctive contribution is that monthly indicators closer to outcome measures are collected directly from district officers rather than waiting for a periodic evaluation report; the district unit necessarily masks divergence within a district. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking,

although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

Counter-position / limit: A constitutional value, commission recommendation, scheme catalogue, budget allocation, portal, disposal count or ranking cannot alone establish lawful authority, inclusive implementation, substantive remedy or attributable outcome; test capacity, federal competence, distribution, privacy, audit, appeal and current operative status.

Qualified conclusion: Delta ranking solves a real demotivation problem created by absolute ranking and introduces a real baseline-gaming problem in its place, so the examination must state the incentive logic and the validation condition on which its credibility depends.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing authority -> institution -> delivery -> outcome -> remedy; define and state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for inclusion, privacy, federal, indicator, grievance and current-status limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains implementation rather than listing schemes, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves legal, federal, institutional, causal and outcome distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine the design choice of ranking districts by the pace of improvement rather than by…”, replace the weakest catalogue-style point with one named duty-holder, legal or executive basis, delivery bottleneck, process and outcome indicator, grievance route and evidence-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Distinguish monitoring from evaluation as governance-information functions and assess India's architecture on that distinction. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: The two functions trade frequency against rigour and neither substitutes for the other, so the architecture must be assessed institution by institution with each body's distinct function, its data basis and the limitation that follows from it.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers.

- The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect.
- The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.
- The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch.

Qualified conclusion: The two functions trade frequency against rigour and neither substitutes for the other, so the architecture must be assessed institution by institution with each body's distinct function, its data basis and the limitation that follows from it.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Distinguish monitoring from evaluation as governance-information functions and assess India's…”, every clause, exact authority and institutional boundary, an implementation chain, stakeholder/accountability map, Centre-state-local allocation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The two functions trade frequency against rigour and neither substitutes for the other, so the architecture must be assessed institution by institution with each body's distinct function, its data basis and the limitation that follows from it.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Monitoring is the continuous, routine and typically self-reported tracking of implementation and immediate outputs, which supports rapid course correction, while evaluation is a periodic and often independent assessment of whether outcomes and impact were actually achieved, which supports scheme redesign, so neither substitutes for the other and conflating them leads either to over-reliance on self-reported dashboards or to under-use of the responsiveness that monitoring offers. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The district dashboard data is initially self-reported by district-level officers and then subject to validation by agencies selected by NITI Aayog, which is a two-stage design that balances the speed and frequency advantage of self-reporting against the reliability advantage of independent checking, although validation capacity and rigour can vary by sector and indicator; an implausibly large one-month jump in an indicator is exactly the case the validation layer exists to catch. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

Counter-position / limit: A constitutional value, commission recommendation, scheme catalogue, budget allocation, portal, disposal count or ranking cannot alone establish lawful authority, inclusive implementation, substantive remedy or attributable outcome; test capacity, federal competence, distribution, privacy, audit, appeal and current operative status.

Qualified conclusion: The two functions trade frequency against rigour and neither substitutes for the other, so the architecture must be assessed institution by institution with each body's distinct function, its data basis and the limitation that follows from it.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing authority -> institution -> delivery -> outcome -> remedy; define and state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for inclusion, privacy, federal, indicator, grievance and current-status limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains implementation rather than listing schemes, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves legal, federal, institutional, causal and outcome distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Distinguish monitoring from evaluation as governance-information functions and assess India's…”, replace the weakest catalogue-style point with one named duty-holder, legal or executive basis, delivery bottleneck, process and outcome indicator, grievance route and evidence-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine why attribution rather than measurement is the hard problem in evaluating a public programme. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Movement in an indicator is easy to observe and hard to explain, so the answer must set out the counterfactual requirement, the baseline precondition and what each available method can and cannot establish before offering any verdict on a programme.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs.

- A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data.
- The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one.
- Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism.

Qualified conclusion: Movement in an indicator is easy to observe and hard to explain, so the answer must set out the counterfactual requirement, the baseline precondition and what each available method can and cannot establish before offering any verdict on a programme.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Examine why attribution rather than measurement is the hard problem in evaluating a public…”, every clause, exact authority and institutional boundary, an implementation chain, stakeholder/accountability map, Centre-state-local allocation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Movement in an indicator is easy to observe and hard to explain, so the answer must set out the counterfactual requirement, the baseline precondition and what each available method can and cannot establish before offering any verdict on a programme.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The difficult question in evaluation is not whether an indicator moved but whether it moved because of the intervention, which requires a counterfactual rather than a simple before-and-after comparison, and without a baseline measured before the intervention no method can produce a defensible outcome claim; the absence of baselines is a recurring and nameable weakness in Indian scheme design, and most current Indian evaluations approximate outcome assessment through before-and-after comparison rather than rigorous causal-inference designs. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** A before-and-after comparison shows that the indicator moved but cannot separate the intervention from everything else that changed, a with-and-without comparison supplies a plausible counterfactual but the comparison group may differ systematically, a randomised controlled trial establishes a causal effect for the population and design studied but has limited external validity, faces ethical and practical limits on randomising an entitlement, measures the variant tested rather than the policy as generally implemented and cannot capture general-equilibrium or political effects, a quasi-experimental design supports causal inference

where randomisation is impossible but depends on assumptions that must be stated and can fail, a process evaluation explains why an outcome did or did not occur without measuring the effect size, a mixed-method design captures effect together with mechanism and beneficiary experience at greater cost and only if genuinely integrated, and administrative-data analysis is continuous and cheap at scale but only as reliable as the incentive of whoever enters the data. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The results chain is the ordered sequence from input through activity and output to outcome and impact, and it is the spine of any demand that asks for an evaluation or an assessment of impact because it locates where the available evidence actually sits, shows where reporting stops, and identifies the rung at which attribution becomes contested; building the chain before citing anything is what converts a descriptive answer into an evaluative one. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

Counter-position / limit: A constitutional value, commission recommendation, scheme catalogue, budget allocation, portal, disposal count or ranking cannot alone establish lawful authority, inclusive implementation, substantive remedy or attributable outcome; test capacity, federal competence, distribution, privacy, audit, appeal and current operative status.

Qualified conclusion: Movement in an indicator is easy to observe and hard to explain, so the answer must set out the counterfactual requirement, the baseline precondition and what each available method can and cannot establish before offering any verdict on a programme.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing authority -> institution -> delivery -> outcome -> remedy; define and state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for inclusion, privacy, federal, indicator, grievance and current-status limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains implementation rather than listing schemes, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves legal, federal, institutional, causal and outcome distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine why attribution rather than measurement is the hard problem in evaluating a public…”, replace the weakest catalogue-style point with one named duty-holder, legal or executive basis, delivery bottleneck, process and outcome indicator, grievance route and evidence-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess whether India's monitoring and evaluation architecture has shifted governance from counting outputs to accounting for outcomes. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: The formal requirement has shifted further than the practice, because dual reporting, an evaluation office and a real-time dashboard now exist while attribution, data incentives and budgetary consequence remain unresolved, so the verdict must be graded and carry a reversal condition.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice.
- The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design.
- The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect.
- The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package.

Qualified conclusion: The formal requirement has shifted further than the practice, because dual reporting, an evaluation office and a real-time dashboard now exist while attribution, data incentives and budgetary consequence remain unresolved, so the verdict must be graded and carry a reversal condition.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess whether India's monitoring and evaluation architecture has shifted governance from…", every clause, exact authority and institutional boundary, an implementation chain, stakeholder/accountability map, Centre-state-local allocation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The formal requirement has shifted further than the practice, because dual reporting, an evaluation office and a real-time dashboard now exist while attribution, data incentives and budgetary consequence remain unresolved, so the verdict must be graded and carry a reversal condition.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Input budgeting is traditional line-item budgeting that tracks how much money is allocated to a category, output budgeting tracks the physical units produced for that allocation, and outcome budgeting links the allocation to the change actually achieved, so the framework represents a deliberate shift from output-focused reporting toward outcome-focused accountability; its unfinished business is that outcome achievement carries no budgetary consequence and that outcome targets can themselves be set undemandingly, so the formal requirement outruns the practice. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework is an annual Union Budget document administered by the Ministry of Finance's Budget Division that requires covered major central-sector and centrally sponsored schemes to state financial outlay, outputs, outcomes, indicators and targets, so budget scrutiny extends beyond expenditure and physical counts, and its central limitation is that it does not cover every scheme in every year; the owners record for the 2026-27 document a coverage of one hundred and seventy-two major schemes at an outlay threshold of five hundred crore rupees or more as checked on 21 July 2026, and that figure must always be cited with its Budget year and never carried forward, because coverage is revised annually by design. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office is an attached office of NITI Aayog whose own website, read on 2 September 2026, states that it was constituted in September 2015 by merging the erstwhile Program Evaluation Office and the Independent Evaluation Office, that it is mandated to actively monitor and evaluate the implementation of schemes, programmes and initiatives of the Government of India in order to strengthen their implementation and scope of delivery on an ongoing basis, and that this requires tracking performance, determining outcomes, diagnosing reasons for poor performance and generating recommendations for course correction; it is an evaluator without authority to redesign, so its findings must be adopted by the line ministry to have effect. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The incidence of a monitoring system is uneven, because the district or block officer both generates the data and is ranked on it, which is the single strongest source of gaming pressure, the frontline worker carries the reporting burden on multiple parallel formats, which itself reduces service time, the line ministry owns the reputational stake in the finding, the evaluator produces evidence without authority to act on it, the Ministry of Finance uses the budget framework to connect allocation to expected results, the beneficiary alone experiences the outcome and is usually surveyed rather than consulted, and the legislature and its public accounts committee convert findings into consequence; the loop closes only where a management response with an accepted action, a responsible owner and a follow-up date is published. On ownership, no direct General Studies Mains demand and no objective demand in the audited 2018-2023, 2024-2025 or 2026 ledgers is routed to this topic, so no demand card is manufactured and no question is invented from the locally held official papers, and no district rank or indicator value, no evaluation finding, effect size or recommendation, no count of completed evaluations, no scheme-coverage percentage without its year and no study attribution is asserted anywhere in this package. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

Counter-position / limit: A constitutional value, commission recommendation, scheme catalogue, budget allocation, portal, disposal count or ranking cannot alone establish lawful authority, inclusive implementation, substantive remedy or attributable outcome; test capacity, federal competence, distribution, privacy, audit, appeal and current operative status.

Qualified conclusion: The formal requirement has shifted further than the practice, because dual reporting, an evaluation office and a real-time dashboard now exist while attribution, data incentives and budgetary consequence remain unresolved, so the verdict must be graded and carry a reversal condition.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing authority -> institution -> delivery -> outcome -> remedy; define and state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for inclusion, privacy, federal, indicator, grievance and current-status limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains implementation rather than listing schemes, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves legal, federal, institutional, causal and outcome distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Assess whether India's monitoring and evaluation architecture has shifted governance from…”, replace the weakest catalogue-style point with one named duty-holder, legal or executive basis, delivery bottleneck, process and outcome indicator, grievance route and evidence-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess the design of an indicator system for a new government programme, including the failure modes it must survive. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: An indicator system is an incentive system, so the assessment must specify the properties a usable indicator requires, name the failure modes that follow from attaching consequences to numbers, and pair each with a correction rather than recommending better monitoring in general.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose.
- The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks.
- Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism.
- Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism.

Qualified conclusion: An indicator system is an incentive system, so the assessment must specify the properties a usable indicator requires, name the failure modes that follow from attaching consequences to numbers, and pair each with a correction rather than recommending better monitoring in general.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess the design of an indicator system for a new government programme, including the…”, every clause, exact authority and institutional boundary, an implementation chain, stakeholder/accountability map, Centre-state-local allocation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, safeguards and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: An indicator system is an incentive system, so the assessment must specify the properties a usable indicator requires, name the failure modes that follow from attaching consequences to numbers, and pair each with a correction rather than recommending better monitoring in general.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** A usable indicator is specific, measurable at a defined frequency, attributable to the intervention, independently verifiable, disaggregable by group and geography, and resistant to manipulation, and an evaluation that recommends better monitoring without specifying these properties has recommended nothing; disaggregation by gender, social group, disability and geography is an evaluation requirement rather than an optional extra, because an average conceals precisely the distributional failure an equity criterion is meant to expose. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The failure modes are Goodhart's problem, in which an indicator that carries a consequence stops measuring and starts being produced, corrected by a basket of indicators, rotation and independent sample audit, self-reported data, in which the entity judged by the number also generates it, corrected by third-party validation and an independent sample survey, aggregation masking, in which a district average conceals block-level and group-level failure, corrected by mandatory disaggregation, output substitution, in which effort shifts toward what is counted, corrected by including quality and outcome indicators rather than coverage alone, survivor and selection effects, in which only reachable beneficiaries are measured, corrected by measuring drop-off and exclusion explicitly, and definition drift, in which an indicator's definition changes between years, corrected by publishing definitions with the series and noting breaks. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Third-party evaluation is assessment conducted by an entity independent of the implementing ministry or agency, and its purpose is to remove the conflict of interest inherent in an agency assessing its own performance, so it is not the same thing as internal departmental self-assessment; its independence is nevertheless conditional rather than automatic, because it depends on who commissions the study, who funds it and who is able to withhold the report from publication, and an evaluation that is not published cannot be contested, replicated or used, which makes publication itself an accountability mechanism. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Evaluation used punitively produces defensive reporting and suppresses the honest failure data that learning requires, so separating the learning use from the accountability use and protecting the first is a genuine institutional design problem; alongside it sit measurability bias, in which what is easy to count crowds out what matters so that enrolment displaces learning and toilets displace use, proportionality, since rigorous evaluation is expensive and slow so the large and the novel should be evaluated while the routine is monitored, the direct trade-off between the frequency of a dashboard and the reliability of its data, the tension between standardised indicators that permit national comparison and context-specific indicators that are locally useful, and the plain fact that an evaluation recommending discontinuation of a flagship programme rarely prevails against political commitment, which is realism rather than cynicism. **Analysis:** Connect authority -> institution and

stakeholder incentives -> frontline implementation -> process/output/outcome effect -> accountability or grievance response. **Qualification:** State the jurisdiction, legal/executive status, Centre-state-local boundary, inclusion/privacy safeguard, causal limit, indicator weakness or residual trade-off.

Counter-position / limit: A constitutional value, commission recommendation, scheme catalogue, budget allocation, portal, disposal count or ranking cannot alone establish lawful authority, inclusive implementation, substantive remedy or attributable outcome; test capacity, federal competence, distribution, privacy, audit, appeal and current operative status.

Qualified conclusion: An indicator system is an incentive system, so the assessment must specify the properties a usable indicator requires, name the failure modes that follow from attaching consequences to numbers, and pair each with a correction rather than recommending better monitoring in general.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing authority -> institution -> delivery -> outcome -> remedy; define and state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for inclusion, privacy, federal, indicator, grievance and current-status limits.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains implementation rather than listing schemes, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves legal, federal, institutional, causal and outcome distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess the design of an indicator system for a new government programme, including the…", replace the weakest catalogue-style point with one named duty-holder, legal or executive basis, delivery bottleneck, process and outcome indicator, grievance route and evidence-status qualification.